Revenue Enablement

Copilot CLI Overview & FAQ

Authors: Ryan Hecht

Status: Completed

Table of contents

General Questions
Availability & Access
Installation & Setup
Features & Capabilities
Security & Privacy
Usage & Limits
Integration & Workflow
Troubleshooting & Support
Enterprise & Compliance
Technical Details
Pricing & Billing
Additional resources

Getting Started, Pricing & Access

Who can access GitHub Copilot CLI?

Copilot CLI is included as a core feature of all GitHub Copilot plans (Free, Pro, Pro+, Business, and Enterprise).

How much does it cost to use Copilot CLI?

Copilot CLI access is included as part of your Copilot subscription. Each interaction with the agent draws on your respective plan's premium request allowance. For additional information on billing, please refer to our documentation.

How do I install and set up Copilot CLI?

There are multiple ways to install and set up Copilot CLI. Install via npm with npm install -g @github/copilot, then authenticate using your existing GitHub credentials. The CLI automatically inherits your organization's Copilot policies and governance settings. Please see the installation guide to read options for Homebrew, WinGet, and more.

Will customers with Copilot Business or Enterprise licenses have access to Copilot CLI?

Yes. Copilot CLI works with your existing Copilot Business or Enterprise subscription – no additional billing or setup required. However, your organization's admin needs to enable Copilot CLI.

What operating systems are supported?

Copilot CLI supports macOS, Linux, and Windows.

Capabilities & Functionality

Can I use Copilot CLI with any code editor?

Copilot CLI operates independently in your terminal and can modify files that any editor can then display, making it useful regardless of your editor choice – especially for editors that don't have official Copilot extensions.

Will Copilot CLI integrate directly into VS Code?

Yes, you can interact with Copilot CLI in the VS Code integrated terminal and in the VS Code chat panel. Please see our docs page for more information.

Can I extend Copilot CLI with custom tools?

Yes, Copilot CLI supports Model Context Protocol (MCP) server integrations, skills, and plugins, allowing you to add custom capabilities and contextual richness tailored to your unique development environment.

Which models can I access with Copilot CLI?

Copilot CLI supports models from multiple foundation model providers, such as Anthropic, Google, and OpenAI. You can switch models per task or use multiple models for the same task when needed.

What types of development tasks work best with Copilot CLI?

Copilot CLI excels at legacy codebase navigation, new repository creation, cross-platform development setup, and multi-step implementations, and any scenario requiring autonomous task execution with terminal-native workflows.

Does Copilot CLI support subagents or multi-agent workflows?

Yes. Copilot CLI supports subagents and multi-agent workflows. With /fleet, you can run the same task across multiple subagents in parallel and converge on one decision-ready result, with full control over what's applied.

How does chat history and session persistence work?

Copilot CLI maintains session persistence within and across sessions, allowing you to build on previous conversations and maintain context throughout your development workflow.

Security & Governance

How does Copilot CLI handle security and compliance?

Copilot CLI automatically inherits your organization's existing Copilot governance policies. It's built on GitHub's trusted platform infrastructure with the same security standards and compliance that protect millions of developers.

How does file modification and command execution work?

Every file change and command execution requires your explicit approval before being applied. You maintain complete visibility and control over all autonomous actions.

General Questions

What is GitHub Copilot CLI?

GitHub Copilot CLI brings AI-powered coding assistance directly to your command line, enabling you to build, debug, and understand code through natural language conversations. Powered by the same agentic harness as GitHub's Copilot coding agent, it provides intelligent assistance while staying deeply integrated with your GitHub workflow.

How is Copilot CLI different from other Copilot features (agent mode, coding agent)?

Copilot CLI is editor agnostic, unlike Agent Mode. Copilot CLI uses the same agentic brain as Coding agent, but runs locally in your terminal rather than in GitHub Actions.

What are the main use cases for Copilot CLI?

- **Massive parallelism (/fleet & /delegate):** Stop doing tasks one by one. Use sub-agents to execute work in parallel—like fixing linting across a whole repo—while you stay in control of the high-level strategy.
- **Zero context loss (CLI to IDE & /resume):** Start a plan in the terminal and finish it in VS Code. Memory and session compaction mean you never have to "re-explain" the problem to the AI.
- **Backlog to implementation (/mcp & Issues):** Copilot acts as a PM. It can search your issues, prioritize your tasks, and summarize the scope so you can start coding immediately without "context hunting."
- **Autonomous execution (/autopilot & /test):** Close the loop. Let Copilot run tests, analyze failures, and apply fixes autonomously so you only intervene when it's time to review the /diff.

Is Copilot CLI replacing any existing GitHub CLI tools?

Copilot CLI is replacing the `gh-copilot` “GitHub Copilot in the CLI” extension for the GitHub CLI https://github.com/github/gh-copilot

How does Copilot CLI compare to competitors like Claude Code, OpenAI Codex CLI, or Cursor CLI?

Feature	GitHub Copilot CLI	Claude Code	Codex CLI	Cursor CLI
Vendor-agnostic	✅Sonnet 4, GPT-5	❌Anthropic only	❌OpenAI only	✅Claude, OpenAI,

models				Gemini, Grok
Pricing	Monthly subscription for explicit number of prompts, pay extra per-prompt	Monthly subscription with nebulous hourly limits, or pay per-token	Monthly subscription with nebulous hourly limits, or pay per-token	Monthly subscription for explicit number of prompts, pay extra per-prompt
Open Source	❌Proprietary	❌Proprietary	✅Apache 2.0	❌Proprietary
Supported Platforms	✅Linux ✅MacOS ✅Windows via WSL 🟡Native Windows (experimental)	✅Linux ✅MacOS ✅Windows via WSL ✅Native Windows	✅Linux ✅MacOS ✅Windows via WSL ❌Native Windows	✅Linux ✅MacOS ✅Windows via WSL ❌Native Windows
Headless/Programmatic Mode	✅	✅	✅	✅
Security: File Editing/Execution Approval	✅	✅	✅	✅
Security: Sandboxing	❌	✅Optional	✅By default	❌
Rich IDE diff/edit Integration	❌(Use VSCode Agent Mode)	✅	❌(Use Codex in the IDE)	❌(Use Cursor IDE agent)
Customization/Extensibility	🟡MCP servers, custom instructions	✅MCP servers, custom instructions, custom slash commands, custom sub-agents, custom response modes	🟡MCP servers, custom instructions, custom prompts	🟡MCP servers, custom instructions, Cursor rules

Availability & Access

Which Copilot plans include access to Copilot CLI?

All paid versions of Copilot, individual, business, and enterprise, can use the CLI

Is Copilot CLI available for free tier users?

No, at this time, only paid Copilot plans can use Copilot CLI

When will Copilot CLI be generally available?

We do not have a GA timeframe at this time.

Proxima?

Yes, Proxima works!

Installation & Setup

How do I install Copilot CLI?

Via NPM! `npm install -g copilot` or `npm install -g @github/copilot`

What are the system requirements for Copilot CLI?

Node.js version 22 or higher, npm version 10 or higher

Does Copilot CLI work on Windows, macOS, and Linux?

We support Linux, macOS, and Windows via WSL (Ubuntu recommended). Powershell support in Windows is experimental

How do I authenticate Copilot CLI with my GitHub account?

Run `/login` once you launch `copilot`

Can I use Copilot CLI with multiple GitHub accounts?

Yes! Use `/user` to manage your logged in users. Log in with a new account with `/login`

Features & Capabilities

What can I do with Copilot CLI?

The use cases of Copilot CLI are similar to that of Agent Mode in the IDE – but editor agnostic, perfect for terminal-native developers.

Can Copilot CLI access my GitHub repositories and issues?

Yes! Copilot CLI ships with the GitHub MCP server enabled by default and can access your GitHub repositories, issues, PR's, and more.

Does Copilot CLI support custom tools and integrations via MCP (Model Context Protocol)?

Yes, users may use the `/mcp` slash command to add additional MCP servers

Can Copilot CLI execute commands on my system?

Yes, Copilot CLI can run commands on your system. See the documentation for information about best security practices.

Does Copilot CLI have access to my entire codebase or just the current directory?

By default, Copilot CLI has access to the directory you launch it in. If it thinks it needs files outside of that directory, you will be prompted to grant it access.

Security & Privacy

What security controls are in place for Copilot CLI?

See the "security considerations" section of the documentation for more information.

Does Copilot CLI require approval before executing commands or modifying files?

Yes, before modifying any files or executing any commands with side effects, you will be prompted to give consent. You can give your consent on a command-by-command basis, or give your consent to the remainder of the session.

How does Copilot CLI handle sensitive data and credentials?

When available, Copilot CLI uses your system keyring to sensitively store your authentication token. If no system secret storage is available, you will be asked whether you are okay with your tokens being stored in plaintext on your computer, or if you would rather `/login` every time you invoke `copilot`

Is my code and conversation history stored when using Copilot CLI?

GitHub does not store your conversation history remotely. It is stored locally on your machine in `~/.copilot` and you can delete it at any time.

Do organization policies apply to Copilot CLI usage?

Yes. Copilot CLI is governed by the "Copilot in the CLI" enterprise policy. Your admin must have it enabled in order to have access

Usage & Limits

Are there rate limits for Copilot CLI?

Copilot CLI does not have any additional rate limits that differ from other Copilot services.

Does Copilot CLI usage count against my premium requests?

Yes, every time a user inputs a prompt, one premium request is used.

Can I use Copilot CLI offline?

No, Copilot CLI requires an internet connection.

Are there any restrictions on the types of tasks I can perform?

GitHub filters harmful prompts as per our responsible AI filters.

Integration & Workflow

Can I use Copilot CLI alongside my IDE's Copilot features?

You can do this by opening a terminal pane in your IDE, but there is no editor light-up for diffs at this time

Can I export or share conversations from Copilot CLI?

You can view your previous conversations in your `~/.copilot` directory

Does Copilot CLI support command history and session persistence?

Yes, you can use `copilot --resume` to resume a previous conversation

Troubleshooting & Support

What should I do if Copilot CLI freezes or crashes?

The process can be killed from your system's task manager and restarted from a new terminal window

How do I report bugs or issues with Copilot CLI?

https://github.com/github/copilot-cli/issues

Where can I find documentation for Copilot CLI?

https://docs.github.com/copilot/concepts/agents/about-copilot-cli

Is there a community forum for Copilot CLI users?

Yes, at https://github.com/github/copilot-cli

How do I check which version of Copilot CLI I'm running?

```
copilot -v
```

How do I update Copilot CLI to the latest version?

```
npm install -g @github/copilot@latest
```

Enterprise & Compliance

Does Copilot CLI support SSO authentication?

Yes, users log in with their GitHub accounts, which supports SSO

Can we restrict Copilot CLI features for our organization?

Yes, you can restrict Copilot CLI in the policies section of your organization.

Technical Details

Which AI model powers Copilot CLI?

By default, Copilot CLI uses Sonnet 4. You can use GPT-5 by setting the `COPILOT_MODEL` environment variable to `gpt-5`

How does Copilot CLI handle context and conversation memory?

Context is truncated via a rolling window, with the oldest parts of the conversation dropping out of context first. Conversations are stored in plaintext in `~/.copilot`

Pricing & Billing

Is there an additional cost for using Copilot CLI?

No, Copilot CLI is included with your subscription and consumes premium requests.

How is Copilot CLI usage tracked for billing purposes?

Every time a user submits a prompt, 1 premium request is used.

Will heavy CLI usage affect my organization's Copilot costs?

Yes, Copilot CLI uses 1 premium request for every user input

Additional resources

- Copilot CLI Overview